



S&P Global

Client Forward: Early Careers in Commercial Functions

A ground-up technical briefing on the firm, its business model, its competitors, and how to win a place at the 17 September event.

Prepared for Janak Chohan · 1 September 2026

Application deadline: **23:59 BST, 14 September 2026** · 13 days remaining

Event: afternoon of 17 September 2026, S&P Global London office

Data current to Q2 2026 results (six months ended 30 June 2026) and the 1 September 2026 S&P Kaiko announcement.

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Part 0 — Read this first

0.1 The five-minute version

S&P Global sells *judgement about risk and value, packaged as data*. It does not lend, trade, underwrite or manage money. It has no balance-sheet risk to speak of. What it owns is a set of reference points that the rest of the financial system has agreed to organise itself around — a credit rating, an index level, a barrel price, a company record — and it charges for access to them.

That produces an unusual economic shape. In FY2025 the firm did **\$15.336bn** of revenue at a **~51% adjusted operating margin**, and the two most profitable divisions — Indices (71% adjusted margin) and Ratings (65%) — are essentially toll booths on activity that happens whether or not S&P Global does anything more that day. It has raised its dividend for **53 consecutive years**. There are perhaps a dozen businesses in the world with this profile.

As of **1 July 2026** the company has four divisions, and they are exactly the four the event covers: **Market Intelligence, Ratings, S&P Dow Jones Indices**, and **Energy** (which the job advert still calls by its old name, Commodity Insights). Mobility was spun out as a separate listed company on 1 July 2026. So "the four divisions" in the advert is not a selection — it is the whole firm.

THE THING TO INTERNALISE BEFORE YOU WRITE A WORD

Commercial roles at S&P Global are not generic B2B sales. You are selling either (a) a regulated product where the people who make it are legally walled off from you, (b) a benchmark whose value is its neutrality, or (c) a data platform fighting Bloomberg for a seat on a trading floor. Each of those has a different commercial logic. Almost nobody applying to this event will know that. Say it and you are immediately in the top decile.

0.2 How the selection actually works

The advert asks for three things: a CV, a 100-word "why this event", and one panel question. There is then a "brief online assessment" for the shortlist. Two structural facts should shape how you allocate effort:

- **This is a networking event, not a job.** S&P Global is filling a room. The bar is "would this person be a credible, engaged participant and a plausible 2027 hire", not "is this the best candidate in Britain". That means the screen is mostly a *filter*, not a *ranking*.
- **They explicitly say earlier applications may get earlier invitations.** With rolling review and an event capacity constraint, applying on day 13 is materially worse than applying on day 2. **Speed is worth more than polish beyond a certain point.** Target submission within 48–72 hours.

My read on weighting is set out in full in §6.4. Short version: **CV ~45%, Q1 ~35%, Q2 ~20%** — but Q2 is the only place where you can be *memorably* better than everyone else, because a hundred people will write near-identical 100-word answers and almost all of them will write a lazy panel question.

0.3 Your 13-day plan

When	What	Why
Day 1–2 (1–2 Sep)	Read Parts 1–3 of this report. Draft Q1 and Q2 from §7. Update CV per §7.3.	Rolling review — get in the first cohort.
Day 2–3	Submit.	Capacity is finite; early applicants get invited earlier.
Day 3–6	Read Parts 4–5. Skim S&P Global's Q2 2026 earnings release and the Nov 2025 Investor Day materials directly.	Prepares you for the online assessment and the event itself.
Day 6–8	Complete the online assessment the moment it arrives.	Assume it is timed from issue; delay reads as low interest.
Day 8–13	Part 8 (talking points) and §6.5 (pitch challenge). Pick one product — Capital IQ Pro or Ratings — and be able to pitch it in 90 seconds.	The pitch challenge is the only competitive element on the day, and selected groups present on stage.
17 Sep, afternoon	Event. Follow-up notes within 24 hours to everyone you meet.	The event exists to build a shortlist for 2027. The follow-up is part of the assessment even if nobody says so.

Part 1 — What S&P Global actually is (from zero)

1.1 The one-sentence answer

S&P Global is an information company that sells the reference points financial markets use to price risk.

Unpack that. Every financial transaction requires the two sides to agree on some facts they did not themselves produce. When a company issues a bond, buyer and seller need a shared view of default risk — that is a *credit rating*. When a pension fund buys "the US stock market", somebody has to define what that is and maintain the list — that is an *index*. When a refinery in Rotterdam buys a cargo of North Sea crude, the contract does not name a number; it names a *published price assessment*. When an analyst models a company, they need standardised financials for it and its peers — that is a *data platform*.

S&P Global produces all four. That is the whole company. Everything else — the AI tools, the events, the research — is either a delivery mechanism for those four things or an attempt to sell more of them.

WHY THIS IS A GOOD BUSINESS, STATED PLAINLY

The reference point is worth almost nothing to produce a second time, and enormously valuable to be *the* one everybody uses. Once the market has coordinated on S&P's number, a competitor with an equally good number has no product, because the value was never accuracy alone — it was *shared acceptance*. This is why margins are 65–71% in Ratings and Indices and why they have been for decades.

1.2 A 165-year history in ten beats

Year	Event	Why it matters
1860	Henry Varnum Poor publishes <i>History of Railroads and Canals in the United States</i> .	The founding act: investors were financing railroads blind. Poor sold them information. That is still the business.
1906	Standard Statistics Bureau founded.	The other half of the eventual name.
1923	Standard Statistics launches a 233-company stock index.	Ancestor of the S&P 500.
1941	Poor's Publishing merges with Standard Statistics → Standard & Poor's .	Ratings and indices under one roof from the start.
1957	The S&P 500 launches in its modern form.	Today the single most licensed financial object on earth.
1966	McGraw-Hill acquires S&P.	The firm spends 50 years inside a publishing conglomerate.
1970s	Rating agencies shift from <i>investor-pays</i> to issuer-pays .	The single most consequential business-model decision in the firm's history (\$2.3).
2007–11	Structured-finance ratings failures; SEC/DoJ actions; S&P downgrades the US to AA+ in Aug 2011; \$1.5bn DoJ settlement in 2015.	The reputational low point. It produced today's regulation and today's internal separation of analytics from commercial.
2016	McGraw Hill Financial renames itself S&P Global .	Publishing identity formally abandoned; the firm becomes a data company.
2022	Merger with IHS Markit completes, 28 Feb — \$44bn enterprise value, all-stock. The largest deal ever in capital-markets information.	Created today's Market Intelligence, Commodity Insights (now Energy) and Mobility. Two-thirds of the current company's revenue base was assembled or reshaped by this deal.
2024–26	Martina Cheung becomes CEO (Nov 2024). Mobility spun off (1 Jul 2026). Commodity Insights renamed Energy (Nov 2025). \$1.8bn With Intelligence acquisition (Nov 2025).	Active portfolio reshaping — the current chapter, and the one to talk about.

1.3 What "Essential Intelligence" means in practice

You will hear the phrase constantly on 17 September. It is a marketing wrapper, but it encodes a real strategic claim, and you should be able to translate it rather than repeat it.

The claim is: *our data is not a commodity because it is not observable elsewhere*. Three of the four divisions produce information that does not exist until S&P Global creates it —

- A **credit rating** is an opinion. Nobody else has it until S&P publishes it.
- A **Platts price assessment** is a constructed number derived from a proprietary process. There is no "true" Dated Brent price sitting on an exchange to look up.
- An **index level** is defined by S&P's own rules and committee decisions.

Only Market Intelligence is largely in the business of collecting and standardising facts that exist independently — and that is precisely why its margin is 34% rather than 65%. **That single observation explains most of the firm's financial structure, and it is the sort of thing that will make a commercial leader look up.**

1.4 The shape of the firm today

\$15.3bn FY2025 REVENUE	~51% ADJ. OP. MARGIN	\$17.83 FY2025 ADJ. EPS	~42,150 EMPLOYEES (DEC 2025)	53 yrs DIVIDEND INCREASES
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- **Listed:** NYSE: SPGI. Market capitalisation was roughly **\$128bn** with the shares around \$431 in late April 2026 — check the current figure before the event, since it moves.
- **Headquarters:** 55 Water Street, New York. Roughly 29 offices worldwide.
- **Where the people are:** India ~48%, United States ~23%, **United Kingdom ~7%**. The UK is the third-largest employee base and London is the effective EMEA headquarters — which is why this event is in London and why the Chief Client Officer is also UK Country Head (\$5.1).
- **Four divisions** post-Mobility: Market Intelligence, Ratings, Energy, Indices.

A DETAIL WORTH USING CAREFULLY

The advert says "S&P Global Commodity Insights". That division was **renamed S&P Global Energy on 14 November 2025**, announced at Investor Day. The recruitment copy is running on the old name. Knowing this shows you read primary sources rather than the job ad — but deliver it as interest, not correction. "I've been following the Energy division since the rebrand" does the work without making anyone wrong.

Part 2 — The business model, mechanism by mechanism

2.1 The four revenue engines

S&P Global reports revenue by *type*, not just by division, and the types are more informative than the divisions. There are effectively four engines, each with a different driver, a different cyclical and a different commercial job attached to it.

Engine	FY2025	% of rev.	What drives it	Commercial job
Subscription	\$7.865bn	51%	Number of seats/licences × price. Renews annually. Very low churn.	Land, adopt, renew, upsell. This is where most graduate commercial roles sit.
Non-subscription / transaction	\$3.144bn	21%	Debt issuance volumes — every rated bond generates a one-off fee. Plus event and one-off data sales.	Relationship coverage of issuers and their banks; you cannot "sell harder" into a closed primary market.
Non-transaction	\$2.054bn	13%	Annual surveillance fees on outstanding rated debt, entity ratings, frequent-issuer programmes, RatingsDirect research.	Programme-level negotiation; the ballast that makes Ratings less cyclical than it looks.
Asset-linked fees	\$1.206bn	8%	AUM in products tracking S&P DJI indices × a few basis points. Moves with market <i>level</i> and with <i>flows</i> .	Licensing: signing ETF issuers and structured-product desks. Very few, very large counterparties.
Recurring variable	\$623m	4%	Usage-scaled contracts (e.g. data consumption that flexes with client activity).	Consumption growth inside existing accounts.
Sales usage-based royalties	\$444m	3%	Per-contract royalties on exchange-traded derivatives on S&P indices; redistribution royalties.	Exchange partnerships (CME, Cboe). Almost pure margin.

Source: S&P Global FY2025 results. Percentages are of \$15.336bn total; components sum exactly.

THE INSIGHT TO CARRY INTO THE ROOM

Roughly **68%** of revenue (subscription + non-transaction + asset-linked + recurring variable) recurs without anyone doing a deal. Roughly **32%** is genuinely transactional. Commercially this means the firm's growth arithmetic is *retention first, expansion second, new logos third* — the opposite of a typical software company. If you are asked "what would you focus on in a commercial role here", that ordering is the correct answer and it is not the obvious one.

2.2 Financial anatomy

DIVISIONAL PERFORMANCE, FY2025

Division	FY2025 revenue	Growth	Reported margin	Adj. margin
Market Intelligence	\$4.916bn	+6%	20%	34%
Ratings	\$4.724bn	+8%	64%	65%
Energy (ex-Commodity Insights)	\$2.299bn	+7%	41%	48%
Indices (S&P DJI)	\$1.850bn	+14%	69%	71%
Mobility (spun off 1 Jul 2026)	\$1.747bn	+9%	22%	40%
Total	\$15.336bn	+8%		

THE 2026 RUN-RATE — WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING RIGHT NOW

Division	Q1 2026 rev.	Q1 growth	Q2 2026 growth	Comment
Market Intelligence	\$1,296m	+8%	+6% (adj.)	With Intelligence contributing; Kensho Data & Platforms high-single-digit.
Ratings	\$1,302m	+13%	+17%	Q2 transaction revenue +25% to \$746m; non-transaction +8% to \$593m. Issuance boom.
Energy	\$652m	+7%	+3% (adj.)	The soft spot. Sanctions, Middle East conflict and volatility suppressed Global Trading Services volumes.
Indices	\$519m	+17%	+20%	13th consecutive record quarter. Asset-linked fees and ETD royalties.

H1 2026 total revenue \$8.318bn, +10.4% year on year. Q1 2026 adjusted operating margin 51.8% (+100bp); Q1 adjusted EPS \$4.97 (+14%).

GUIDANCE AND CAPITAL RETURN

- **FY2026 guidance:** reported revenue growth 6.3–8.3%; organic constant-currency 6.0–8.0%; adjusted diluted EPS \$19.40–\$19.65; margin expansion 10–35bp. Divisional guidance was raised at Q2: Ratings to 5–8%, Indices to 12–14%, Market Intelligence 5.5–7%, Energy 4.5–6%.
- **FY2025 capital return:** \$1.2bn dividends + \$5.0bn buybacks = **\$6.2bn, or 113% of adjusted free cash flow**. The 2026 policy targets ≥85% of adjusted FCF. Quarterly dividend \$0.97, the 53rd consecutive annual increase.

READ THAT CAPITAL-RETURN LINE CAREFULLY

Returning *more than* free cash flow means the firm is not reinvesting to grow organically at scale — it is buying growth selectively (\$4.3) and returning the rest. For a commercial hire this matters: the growth targets are expected to come from **the existing client base and cross-sell**, not from a spending war. That is a direct argument for why commercial roles are load-bearing here rather than a support function.

2.3 Division deep dive: S&P Global Ratings

\$4.72BN FY2025

65% ADJ. MARGIN

MOST REGULATED

WHAT IT DOES

It publishes forward-looking opinions on the creditworthiness of debt issuers and individual debt instruments, expressed on the familiar scale — AAA, AA+, AA ... BBB- (the investment-grade floor) ... down through BB+ and below to D. A rating is an opinion on *relative likelihood of default* (and, for some instruments, expected loss), not a buy recommendation and not a price.

HOW THE MONEY WORKS — THE ISSUER-PAYS MODEL

This is the mechanism most applicants cannot explain, and it is worth being precise.

1. A company, bank, government or structured vehicle wants to raise debt. Investors will demand a materially higher yield for unrated paper, and many institutional buyers are *mandated* — by their own investment policy, or by capital regulation — to hold only rated instruments above a threshold.
2. So **the issuer** (usually via its investment bank) commissions the rating and pays for it. Fees are typically scaled to issue size in basis points, with floors and caps.
3. That new-issue fee is **transaction revenue**. It is one-off and it is entirely dependent on issuance volumes, which is why Ratings revenue swings with the debt cycle. Q2 2026 transaction revenue was \$746m, up 25% year on year, on a strong issuance backdrop.
4. The rating then has to be *surveilled* for the life of the instrument — reviewed, affirmed, upgraded, downgraded, put on CreditWatch. Issuers pay ongoing annual fees, and large repeat issuers negotiate **frequent-issuer programmes** that bundle a year's ratings. This is **non-transaction revenue**: \$593m in Q2 2026, +8%. It is the ballast.
5. Separately, investors pay *subscriptions* for ratings research and data — RatingsDirect, RatingsXpress and the credit research feeds, largely delivered through Market Intelligence's distribution.

THE CONFLICT OF INTEREST, AND HOW IT IS MANAGED — KNOW THIS COLD

The obvious objection to issuer-pays is that the person paying wants a high rating. This is not a hypothetical: mis-rated structured products were central to the 2008 crisis and cost S&P a \$1.5bn DoJ settlement in 2015.

The answer, now enforced by regulation, is **analytical separation**. Under the EU Credit Rating Agency Regulation (1060/2009), supervised directly by **ESMA**, and equivalent SEC rules for **NRSROs**, commercial staff are structurally walled off from the rating process. Fee discussions cannot involve analysts; analysts' compensation cannot be linked to the revenue from the issuers they rate; rating committees, not salespeople, decide outcomes. S&P Global Ratings Europe Limited is the ESMA-registered Dublin entity; the UK business is FCA-registered.

Why you should care: a commercial role in Ratings is genuinely different from any other sales job you will ever have. You cannot promise an outcome, you cannot discount for a result, and your product's entire value depends on your inability to influence it. If you can articulate that at the event you will be the only one who does.

THE MOAT

Three of the "Big Three" — S&P, Moody's and Fitch — hold roughly 95% of the global market, with S&P and Moody's each around 40% and Fitch 15–20%. The barrier is not analytical skill; it is **regulatory recognition plus incumbency in mandates**. Bank capital rules, insurance solvency rules and thousands of individual fund mandates are written referencing ratings from recognised agencies. Rewriting those documents to admit a new entrant is a coordination problem no start-up can solve.

WHERE GROWTH IS COMING FROM

- **Private credit.** This is the live story. As lending migrated from banks to direct lenders, the debt still needed ratings for the structures that hold it. S&P's *credit estimates* — lighter-touch assessments used in middle-market CLOs — have **more than doubled since 2021, from about 1,200 to over 2,800**. The private-credit CLO market was around **\$155bn outstanding as of October 2025, roughly 16% of the \$977bn US CLO market**. Add BDCs, interval funds, collateralised fund obligations and fund ratings.
- **Sovereign and geopolitical repricing.** S&P downgraded **France from AA– to A+ on 20 October 2025**, citing fiscal and political uncertainty, with public debt projected to rise from 112% of GDP (2024) to 121% by 2028. The AAA club is now down to roughly eleven sovereigns.

2.4 Division deep dive: S&P Dow Jones Indices

\$1.85BN FY2025

71% ADJ. MARGIN

HIGHEST MARGIN IN THE FIRM

WHAT IT DOES

It defines, calculates, maintains and licenses indices — the S&P 500, the Dow Jones Industrial Average, the S&P/ASX 200, the VIX methodology, thousands of others. An index is a rulebook plus a maintained constituent list plus a calculated level. That is genuinely all it is, and it is one of the best businesses in the world.

HOW THE MONEY WORKS — THREE STREAMS

1. **Asset-linked fees (the big one).** An ETF or fund that tracks an S&P index pays a licence fee calculated as basis points on assets under management. For the S&P 500 the widely-cited structure is around **3 basis points of AUM plus a fixed component** (roughly \$600,000 in the SPY arrangement). More than 95% of licensing fees are AUM-percentage-based rather than flat. The consequence: when SPY held around \$400bn, S&P DJI collected well over \$120m from that single fund.
2. **Exchange-traded derivatives royalties.** CME pays a per-contract royalty on E-mini S&P 500 futures and options; Cboe on VIX products. Volume-driven, and volumes spike precisely when markets are volatile — a natural hedge against the AUM stream falling in a selloff.
3. **Data and custom indices.** Subscriptions to index constituent and level data, plus bespoke index construction for asset managers and banks (custom benchmarks, structured-product underlyings, direct indexing).

WHY THE MARGIN IS 71%

The marginal cost of the ten-billionth dollar of AUM tracking the S&P 500 is approximately zero. The index is calculated once, whether one fund tracks it or four hundred do. Revenue scales with the market; cost does not. This is the purest operating leverage in the whole company — and it is why Indices grew 14% in FY2025 and 20% in Q2 2026 while Ratings grew 8%.

THE ONE GENUINELY CONTENTIOUS FEATURE: THE INDEX COMMITTEE

Unlike FTSE Russell's largely mechanical rules, **S&P 500 membership is decided by a committee** applying published criteria with discretion. The committee can and does exercise judgement about timing and suitability. This is a real point of differentiation — S&P argues committee governance produces a more stable, more investable, lower-turnover benchmark; critics argue it is opaque discretion over trillions of dollars of passive flows. **This is excellent material for a panel question** (\$7.2).

COMPETITIVE POSITION

The 2025 indexing industry was worth a record **\$7.2bn**. S&P DJI led with **\$1.85bn**, MSCI's index business followed at roughly **\$1.79bn**, FTSE Russell third at about **\$1.29bn**. Those three account for more than **80% of European passive equity fund assets**. This is a tight oligopoly with S&P narrowly in front — largely because it owns the single most important index in the world.

WHAT IS NEW

- **S&P Pantera Digital Asset Index** (21 July 2026) — an 18-asset institutional benchmark that pointedly *excludes Bitcoin and meme coins*, screening instead for real-world usage, measurable revenue, liquidity and listing standards. Top holdings include Ethereum, BNB, Solana, Tron and Hyperliquid.
- **S&P Kaiko Digital Asset Indices** (announced **1 September 2026** — the day this report was written). A co-branded suite combining Kaiko's crypto-native reference rates and data infrastructure with S&P DJI's index administration, licensing and distribution. Over **4,000 rates and indices** at launch, for ETPs, futures, options and structured products.

USE THIS

The Kaiko deal is **sixteen days old** at the time of the event. Almost nobody in the room will have seen it. It is also a perfect illustration of the commercial model: S&P contributed *distribution, licensing and benchmark administration* — not data — while Kaiko contributed the data. That is the firm monetising its brand and its regulatory standing as a benchmark administrator. Referencing it demonstrates you understand what S&P actually sells.

2.5 Division deep dive: Market Intelligence

\$4.92BN FY2025

34% ADJ. MARGIN

LARGEST BY REVENUE, MOST COMPETITIVE

WHAT IT DOES

This is the division that looks most like a conventional software and data business, and it is the largest by revenue. It sells multi-asset data, analytics and workflow tools to investment managers, banks, private equity firms, insurers, corporates and government agencies. Formally it now sits under the banner "**Market Intelligence, Kensho Data & Platforms**".

THE PRODUCT STACK

Product	What it is	Who buys it
S&P Capital IQ Pro	The flagship desktop: company fundamentals, estimates, filings, transcripts, screening, comps, M&A and capital-markets transaction data, an Excel plug-in.	Investment banking analysts, PE associates, equity research, corporate development. Sell-side heavy.
Data & Feeds (Xpressfeed and similar)	The same content delivered as bulk feeds and APIs into a client's own systems rather than a screen.	Quant funds, enterprise data teams, anyone building their own stack. Structurally the growth channel.
Credit & Risk Solutions	RatingsXpress and RatingsDirect distribution, Credit Analytics, probability-of-default models, counterparty risk scoring.	Bank risk functions, insurers, corporate treasury. Note: this <i>distributes</i> Ratings' output — the clearest cross-divisional revenue link in the firm.
Private markets	iLEVEL portfolio monitoring — roughly 700 clients including ~250 investment consultants, LPs and asset owners, with a data footprint touching about 16,000 funds . Plus With Intelligence (allocator and fund intelligence, acquired for \$1.8bn).	GPs, LPs, fund administrators, consultants. The declared high-growth adjacency.
Visible Alpha	Granular consensus estimates built from sell-side models at line-item level, not just headline EPS.	Long-only and hedge fund analysts.
Kensho	The in-house AI unit (acquired 2018) — NLP, entity linking, transcript and document intelligence. The engine behind ChatIQ and Document Intelligence.	Internal capability, increasingly a client-facing layer.

WHY THE MARGIN IS ONLY 34%

Be able to explain this — it is the most common thing candidates get wrong by assuming all of S&P Global is a 65%-margin machine.

1. **Real cost of goods.** Collecting, cleaning, normalising and maintaining company fundamentals across tens of thousands of entities is labour- and engineering-intensive, forever. An index rulebook is not.
2. **Genuine competition.** Unlike Ratings and Indices, this division has four serious rivals selling substitutable products — Bloomberg, LSEG Workspace, FactSet and MSCI. Pricing power is bounded.
3. **Seat-based economics.** Growth requires either more seats (headcount-dependent, and financial services headcount is not growing) or higher price per seat (resisted). Hence the strategic pivot toward feeds, enterprise agreements and private markets, where the ceiling is higher.

MARKET SHARE, HONESTLY STATED

Bloomberg, LSEG, FactSet and S&P Global Market Intelligence together represent roughly **\$33.4bn of 2025 revenue** and cover around **95% of investment banking and private equity seats** globally. Within that, Capital IQ holds roughly **6%** share against FactSet's ~4.5% — with Bloomberg dominant. So Market Intelligence is a strong number three or four in a market it does not lead. **Saying this out loud is a credibility move.** Everyone else will claim S&P Global is number one at everything; the firm's own leaders know Market Intelligence is the challenger, and the strategy is built around that fact.

HOW IT IS TRYING TO WIN

- **Price and position, not feature parity.** Capital IQ Pro competes on cost per seat and on depth of fundamentals rather than on matching a Bloomberg Terminal function for function.
- **Cross-sell the unique assets.** Nobody else can bundle credit ratings data, Platts benchmarks, S&P index data and company fundamentals in one enterprise agreement. That is the single strongest commercial argument the firm has (\$3.3).
- **Agent-native architecture.** S&P is exposing Capital IQ Pro data and capabilities through **Model Context Protocol (MCP) servers** so that clients' own AI agents can consume it. Strategically this is a bet that in an agentic world the winner is whoever holds the licensed, rights-cleared underlying data — not whoever owns the prettiest screen. It is also a risk: it decouples revenue from seats.
- **Pruning.** Enterprise Data Management and thinkFolio were sold to Symphony Technology Group on 12 January 2026 for a \$172m pre-tax gain. Software that is not data is being cut.

2.6 Division deep dive: S&P Global Energy (formerly Commodity Insights)

\$2.30BN FY2025

48% ADJ. MARGIN

RENAMED NOV 2025

WHAT IT DOES

It serves producers, consumers, traders and intermediaries across energy, chemicals, shipping, metals, carbon and agriculture. Since the November 2025 rebrand the division presents four capabilities:

- **Platts** — price assessments and news. The crown jewel.
- **CERA** — research and advisory (and CERAWEEK, the industry's flagship conference).
- **Horizons** — energy expansion and sustainability solutions.
- **Events** — a genuine revenue line, not marketing.

HOW PLATTS ACTUALLY WORKS — THE MARKET ON CLOSE MECHANISM

This is the single most technically interesting thing in the entire company, and it is almost never mentioned by candidates.

There is no exchange that tells you the price of physical North Sea crude. Cargoes trade bilaterally, irregularly, in varying grades. So Platts *constructs* the price through a structured process:

1. **The MOC window.** Platts runs a defined assessment window ending at precisely **16:30:00 London time**. Participants submit bids, offers and expressions of interest through Platts' system.
2. **Transparency by publication.** Platts publishes those bids, offers and confirmed trades. A participant who bids must be willing to transact — you cannot post a price you would not honour.
3. **Assessment.** Platts assesses the *tradable, repeatable* value at the instant of close. **Dated Brent** reflects the most competitive of the qualifying light North Sea grades for cargoes loading **10–21 days forward**.
4. **Editorial judgement.** Where the window is thin, Platts editors apply methodology-governed judgement — normalising for grade, timing and location. The combination of structured observation *and* judgement is the defining design feature, and the enduring source of academic and industry debate about it.

WHY THIS MATTERS COMMERCIALY

Dated Brent and its siblings are written into the contracts. National oil companies set **Official Selling Prices** as a differential to a Platts assessment. Derivatives settle against it. Long-term supply agreements reference it. Hundreds of billions of dollars of annual physical crude trade price off a number that a team of editors publishes at 16:30 London time.

So the product is not "data". The product is **the market's agreement to use this number**. A competitor with a more accurate assessment still has nothing, because contracts already name Platts. Say this and you have demonstrated you understand network effects in a way no textbook answer does.

COMPETITION

Argus Media (founded 1970, privately held) is the principal global rival. Its methodology differs meaningfully: **Argus North Sea Dated** reflects a basket of five North Sea grades — Brent, Forties, Oseberg, Ekofisk and Troll — assessed FOB, together with US WTI Midland, triangulated against contracts for difference and forwards. **OPIS** (US refined products, now owned by News Corp) is the third major price reporting agency — and it ended up at News Corp precisely because the DoJ forced its divestiture from the IHS Markit deal (\$4.1). Knowing that connection is a genuine differentiator.

THE CURRENT PROBLEM, AND THE CURRENT FIX

Energy is the softest division right now: **+3% adjusted in Q2 2026**, with mid-single-digit growth in Platts offset by weak Global Trading Services volumes, hit by sanctions, Middle East conflict and unusual volatility. Guidance for FY2026 is 4.5–6%, the lowest of the four.

The strategic response, announced 24 April 2026, is to **stop selling software and double down on proprietary data**: the geoscience and petroleum engineering software portfolio is being sold to **SLB** (closing H2 2026 or early 2027), with a continuing partnership under which S&P distributes its data through the divested tools and co-develops upstream AI models. In its place S&P is launching **Titan**, an AI-native upstream data platform covering **113 countries** and targeting roughly **110,000 users across 4,000 client organisations**.

2.7 Mobility — and why its absence matters

S&P Global Mobility (automotive data: VIN-level vehicle records, forecasting, dealer and aftermarket analytics) was **spun off on 1 July 2026** as **Mobility Global Inc.**, ticker **MBGL**, distributed one-for-one to S&P Global shareholders. It did \$1.747bn of revenue in FY2025.

The logic: it served automotive clients, not financial ones, so it shared no customers, no sales force and no distribution with the rest of the firm. Removing it makes S&P Global a pure financial-and-commodity-markets information company. **This is a commercial-strategy story, not a finance story** — the firm removed the one division that could not be cross-sold. That is exactly the logic a commercial hire should notice.

2.8 Follow the pound: four concrete revenue journeys

1. A UK CORPORATE ISSUES A €500M BOND

Treasury team decides to issue → mandates banks → banks advise that a rating is needed for the target investor base → issuer engages S&P Global Ratings and pays a fee scaled to issue size (**transaction revenue**) → an analytical team, walled off from the fee discussion, runs a rating committee → the rating publishes → for the bond's life the issuer pays annual **surveillance fees** (non-transaction revenue) → simultaneously, hundreds of investors read the rating and its rationale via RatingsDirect and RatingsXpress, sold by **Market Intelligence** as a subscription. *One credit opinion, three revenue lines, two divisions.*

2. AN ASSET MANAGER LAUNCHES A EUROPEAN S&P 500 ETF

Product team designs the fund → needs to licence the index → signs a licence with **S&P DJI** paying roughly 3bp of AUM plus a fixed fee (**asset-linked fees**) → the ETF gathers assets, so S&P's revenue rises with no incremental work → market makers hedge with CME E-mini futures, generating **ETD royalties** → the manager also subscribes to index constituent data (**subscription**). *One licence, three revenue lines, one division, near-zero marginal cost.*

3. A REFINER BUYS A CARGO OF CRUDE

Trader agrees a cargo priced at "Dated Brent plus \$1.20" → the number comes from the **Platts** assessment at 16:30 London → both counterparties subscribe to Platts to see it (**subscription**) → the trader hedges on ICE, whose Brent contract chain ultimately references the physical benchmark → the refiner's strategy team buys **CERA** research on refining margins → executives attend a paid **Energy event**. *One assessment, four revenue lines.*

4. BARCLAYS SIGNS AN ENTERPRISE AGREEMENT (A REAL 2025 DEAL)

On **23 July 2025**, S&P Global and Barclays signed a multi-year strategic agreement. Barclays got **enterprise-wide access** to S&P Global's product suite — Capital IQ Pro plus cross-asset pricing and valuation services across bonds, loans, credit and derivatives. In return, **Barclays contributes its own proprietary data** to improve S&P's pricing and valuation services.

Sally Moore, S&P Global's Chief Client Officer: *"Through this agreement, we are empowering the Barclays enterprise to access our world-class research, data, and solutions."* Stephen Dainton, President of Barclays Bank PLC: *"S&P's unique data, scale, and commitment to innovation will enable Barclays to continue executing against our business strategy."*

This is the single best example of what senior commercial work at S&P Global looks like, and you should have it ready: it is multi-year, enterprise-wide rather than seat-by-seat, cross-divisional, and it is a *two-way data relationship* rather than a simple sale. Note the structure — the client became a supplier. That is a commercial model, not a transaction.

2.9 The moat map

Division	Type of moat	Strength	What would actually break it
Ratings	Regulatory recognition + mandate incumbency	Very high	Regulators removing rating references from capital rules; a shift to investor-pays; sustained reputational failure.
Indices	Network effect + brand + committee governance	Very high	Fee compression from ETF issuers building self-indexed products; a credible cheap substitute for the S&P 500.
Energy (Platts)	Contractual embedding of benchmarks	High	Exchange-traded physical benchmarks displacing assessed prices; regulatory intervention in benchmark administration; Argus winning a major grade.
Market Intelligence	Switching costs + breadth	Moderate	Bloomberg bundling harder; AI collapsing the value of a research desktop; open data eroding fundamentals pricing.

2.10 What actually goes wrong — the risks worth naming

- **Issuance cyclicality.** Roughly a fifth of firm revenue depends on debt being issued. A rates shock or a credit freeze hits transaction revenue hard and immediately.
- **Market beta in Indices.** Asset-linked fees fall with markets. A 20% drawdown mechanically reduces the highest-margin revenue in the firm.
- **AI cuts both ways.** S&P's own filings flag that "AI presents new and evolving risks". If clients' agents can synthesise research from cheaper sources, the research and desktop layer commoditises. S&P's answer is that licensed, rights-cleared, audited data becomes *more* valuable when everything else is generated — but that is a thesis, not a fact.
- **Regulatory tail risk in Ratings.** ESMA has previously found compliance failings at S&P Global Ratings Europe. The licence to operate is a permission, not a property right.
- **Free and cheap substitutes.** The 10-K explicitly warns that "increased availability of free or relatively inexpensive information sources may materially reduce demand" — most directly a Market Intelligence risk.
- **Geopolitics in Energy.** Sanctions regimes and conflict directly suppressed Global Trading Services volumes in Q2 2026. This is not abstract.

Being able to name two real risks unprompted is one of the fastest ways to signal that you have read primary sources rather than a careers page.

Part 3 — Competitors and genuine differentiation

3.1 The scoreboard

Company	FY2025 revenue	What it is	Where it collides with S&P Global
S&P Global	\$15.34bn	Ratings + indices + commodity benchmarks + data platform	—
Moody's	\$7.7bn (+9%)	MIS ratings \$4.1bn; Moody's Analytics \$3.6bn (ARR \$3.5bn, 97% recurring)	Direct rival in Ratings; MA competes with Credit & Risk Solutions. No index business.
LSEG	£9.0bn (+7.6%)	Exchange + clearing + Data & Analytics (ex-Refinitiv) + FTSE Russell	Workspace vs Capital IQ Pro; FTSE Russell vs S&P DJI. The broadest overlap of any rival.
Bloomberg	~\$13bn (private)	The Terminal, plus data, news, indices	Dominant in Market Intelligence's market. The one competitor S&P cannot out-scale.
MSCI	\$3.13bn (+9.7%)	Indices (~\$1.79bn), analytics, ESG/climate, private assets (Burgiss)	Closest pure competitor to S&P DJI. Asset-based fees grew 20.7% in 2025.
FactSet	\$2.32bn (+5.4%)	Research and analytics workstation; organic ASV \$2.37bn (+5.7%)	Direct Capital IQ Pro rival. Also bought S&P's CUSIP business for \$1.925bn.
Argus Media	Private	Price reporting agency	Direct Platts rival across crude, products, gas, metals.
Fitch (Hearst)	Private	Third rating agency, 15–20% share	Ratings. Often used as the tie-breaker when S&P and Moody's disagree.
ICE	—	Exchange group with a large fixed-income data business	Pricing and reference data; Brent futures complex.
Morningstar / PitchBook	—	Private-markets and fund data	Private markets — the contested growth area.

3.2 Head-to-head by division

RATINGS VS MOODY'S — A NEAR-PERFECT DUOPOLY

S&P ~40%, Moody's ~40%, Fitch 15–20%. Both leaders did roughly \$4.1–4.7bn of ratings revenue in 2025 at similar margins. Practical differences worth knowing:

- **Scale of coverage.** S&P generally rates more entities and more instruments, particularly in structured finance and public finance.
- **Analytics.** Moody's Analytics is a bigger, more separately-branded business (\$3.6bn, 97% recurring) than S&P's equivalent, which is distributed *through* Market Intelligence rather than standing alone. Moody's has arguably built the better standalone risk-software franchise.
- **Portfolio.** S&P has indices and commodity benchmarks. Moody's has neither. This is the structural difference (\$3.3).

INDICES VS MSCI AND FTSE RUSSELL

	S&P DJI	MSCI	FTSE Russell (LSEG)
2025 index revenue	\$1.85bn	~\$1.79bn	~\$1.29bn
Flagship	S&P 500, DJIA, VIX methodology	MSCI World, EM, ACWI	FTSE 100, Russell 2000
Home turf	US equity — the largest pool	International/EM allocation	UK and US small-cap
Governance	Committee with discretion	Rules-based	Rules-based
Adjacent strength	Ratings, Platts, Capital IQ	ESG/climate, risk analytics, Burgiss private assets	Exchange, clearing, Workspace

MSCI is the sharper pure-play: better positioned in ESG/climate analytics and, via Burgiss, in private-asset benchmarking. S&P DJI's advantage is owning the benchmark that the world's largest equity market defaults to.

MARKET INTELLIGENCE VS BLOOMBERG, LSEG, FACTSET

The honest positioning: **Bloomberg wins the trading floor; S&P and FactSet fight over research, banking and private equity desks; LSEG competes on breadth and price.** S&P is not going to displace the Terminal, and its strategy does not attempt to. It attempts three things instead — depth of fundamentals and transaction data, a lower price point per seat, and the bundling advantage nobody else has.

ENERGY VS ARGUS, OPIS, WOOD MACKENZIE

Platts leads in crude and in most refined-product benchmarks; Argus is genuinely strong and leads in several specific markets, particularly parts of the US products, fertiliser and metals complex; OPIS leads US downstream/retail fuel. On the research side, **Wood Mackenzie** competes with CERA in upstream and power research. The SLB divestiture and Titan launch are S&P's response to Wood Mackenzie and the upstream software vendors: exit the software, keep the data.

PRIVATE MARKETS — THE GENUINELY CONTESTED LAND GRAB

This is where all the money is going, and it has consolidated fast:

- **Burgiss** → **MSCI**
- **Preqin** → **BlackRock**
- **PitchBook** → **Morningstar**
- **With Intelligence** → **S&P Global** (\$1.8bn, Nov 2025), on top of **iLEVEL**

S&P's differentiated angle is **asset- and deal-level granularity**. Because iLEVEL runs the GP-to-LP reporting pipeline for around 700 clients and touches roughly 16,000 funds, S&P sits on the actual portfolio-company data flowing from managers to investors — not just fund-level returns. It frames this as a new category complementary to Preqin and PitchBook rather than a substitute. **Whether that framing survives contact with BlackRock's distribution is the open question, and it is a legitimate thing to be curious about at the event.**

3.3 The one structural difference — say this and you will be remembered

THE DIFFERENTIATION, IN ONE PARAGRAPH

S&P Global is the only firm that occupies a top-two position in credit ratings, in equity indices, and in commodity price benchmarks simultaneously — and also sells a top-four financial data platform. Moody's has ratings but no index or commodity franchise. MSCI has indices but no ratings and no commodities. Argus has commodity benchmarks and nothing else. Bloomberg has the platform but not the reference points. LSEG has an exchange and FTSE Russell but no ratings.

That is not a boast about size. It is a specific commercial claim: **S&P Global is the only vendor that can sit in front of a bank and negotiate one enterprise agreement spanning credit, equity, commodities and company data.** The Barclays deal is the proof. Everyone else has to be a point solution in someone else's stack.

The counter-argument you should also hold, because it is the sophisticated view: *conglomerate breadth only creates value if the divisions actually sell together.* For a decade they largely did not — they were separate businesses with separate sales forces and separate P&Ls. The creation of the **Chief Client Office**, the Mobility spin-off, and enterprise deals like Barclays are all attempts to finally make the breadth pay. **That is the strategic project a 2027 commercial graduate would actually be joining.** If you can say that, you have understood the firm better than the job advert does.

3.4 Where S&P Global is weaker — be able to say this too

- **Market Intelligence is a challenger, not a leader.** ~6% seat share against Bloomberg's dominance, and a 34% margin that drags the group average.
- **Slowest-growing large division is the biggest one.** MI grew 6% in FY2025 against Indices' 14%. Growth is concentrated in the smallest division.
- **Energy is under pressure.** +3% adjusted in Q2 2026, guided to the lowest growth of the four, exposed to sanctions and geopolitical disruption it cannot control.
- **No ESG/climate analytics franchise of MSCI's stature.** S&P sold a chunk of its ESG ratings capability and has repositioned around "energy expansion" rather than pure sustainability — arguably commercially sensible, but it ceded ground.
- **Reputational overhang in Ratings.** The 2008 structured-finance failures and the 2015 settlement are a permanent part of how the business is regulated and perceived.
- **The AI question is unresolved.** If agents can assemble research from anywhere, does a research desktop still command a seat fee? S&P's MCP strategy is a hedge, not an answer.

Tactical note: at the event, lead with the strength, hold the weaknesses in reserve. Deploy one weakness only if you are asked a challenging question or want to demonstrate depth in a small-group conversation. Volunteering criticism unprompted at a networking event reads as posturing; producing it when probed reads as rigour.

Part 4 — Strategy, deals and the last five years

4.1 The IHS Markit merger (2022) — the deal that made today's firm

- **Announced** November 2020, **closed 28 February 2022**. All-stock, **\$44bn enterprise value** including \$4.8bn of IHS Markit net debt. The largest transaction ever in capital-markets information.
- **What S&P Global bought:** the assets that became today's Market Intelligence (much of it), Commodity Insights/Energy (Platts had already been S&P's, but IHS brought CERA, upstream and chemicals), and Mobility.
- **What the DoJ made them sell** — worth knowing, because it explains today's competitive map:
 - **CUSIP Global Services** → **FactSet, \$1.925bn**. S&P sold the securities-identifier monopoly to a competitor.
 - **IHS Markit's Base Chemicals, OPIS, Coal Metals & Mining, PetroChem Wire** → **News Corp.** The DoJ required divestiture of three price reporting agency businesses to prevent Platts from absorbing its rivals — plus a waiver of a non-compete.
 - **Leveraged Commentary & Data (LCD)** and the associated leveraged-loan indices were also divested.

THE LESSON EMBEDDED IN THOSE DIVESTITURES

The regulator's judgement was that **price benchmarks are the part of this business where market power is dangerous**. S&P was allowed to become the largest financial-information company in the world, but was not allowed to own OPIS alongside Platts. That tells you exactly where the firm's real economic power sits — and it is a genuinely sophisticated observation to make in conversation.

4.2 Portfolio surgery under Martina Cheung (Nov 2024 – present)

Cheung became President and CEO in November 2024, having previously run Market Intelligence and, before that, S&P Global Ratings. Her tenure has been defined less by big acquisitions than by **subtraction**:

Move	When	Rationale
OSTTRA joint venture sold (to KKR)	Announced 2025, closing H2 2025	Post-trade infrastructure JV with CME — infrastructure, not information.
Mobility spin-off → Mobility Global Inc (MBGL)	Announced Apr 2025; effective 1 Jul 2026	Automotive clients share nothing with financial-markets clients. Simplification and focus.
EDM and thinkFolio sold to Symphony Technology Group	12 Jan 2026, \$172m pre-tax gain	Exit workflow software that is not data.
Geoscience and petroleum engineering software → SLB	Announced Apr 2026, closing H2 2026/early 2027	Same logic in Energy: keep the data, sell the tools, partner on distribution and AI.
Commodity Insights renamed S&P Global Energy	14 Nov 2025	Sharpen identity around energy intelligence.

The pattern is unmistakable and you should name it: sell the software, keep the data, keep the benchmark. Four separate transactions, one thesis. Software is competed away; proprietary reference data is not.

4.3 The bolt-on programme — buying into the growth adjacencies

Target	When	Price	What it buys
With Intelligence (from Motive Partners)	Agreed Oct 2025, completed 25 Nov 2025	\$1.8bn	Allocator and fund intelligence in alternatives — roughly \$130m of revenue with high-teens organic ACV growth. The declared move to leadership in private markets intelligence.
ORBCOMM AIS data services	10 Nov 2025	—	Satellite vessel-tracking data — feeds Energy's trade-flow analytics. Physical-world data as an input to commodity intelligence.
Visible Alpha	2024	—	Line-item consensus estimates from sell-side models.
ProntoNLP	2025	—	Sentiment analysis on earnings transcripts.
Drift AI	Mar 2026	—	AI-powered Excel capability, integrated into the Capital IQ Pro Excel plug-in.
Farsight (minority investment + partnership)	Jul 2026	Minority stake	Generates pitch decks, CIMs and valuation materials <i>inside</i> Capital IQ Pro.
McKinsey PriceMetrix (via Crisil)	2025	—	Wealth-management benchmarking. Note Crisil, S&P's majority-owned Indian affiliate, acquires independently.

4.4 Investor Day 2025 — the medium-term targets

Held 13 November 2025 in New York. The three stated strategic objectives:

1. **Advance market leadership** in the core franchises.
2. **Expand into high-growth adjacencies** — explicitly **private markets** and **energy expansion**.
3. **Amplify enterprise capabilities and AI**.

Medium-term financial targets, *excluding Mobility*:

7–9% ORGANIC CC REVENUE GROWTH	50–75bp ANNUAL MARGIN EXPANSION	Double digit ADJ. EPS GROWTH P.A.	30m SHARE BUYBACK AUTHORISED
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Note the gap: FY2026 guidance is 6.0–8.0% organic constant-currency growth against a 7–9% medium-term target. The firm is guiding below its own medium-term ambition this year — Energy's weakness is the main reason. That is a precise, defensible observation.

4.5 The AI strategy — what it actually is

Three distinguishable layers. Most candidates will say "they're investing in AI"; you can say which layer and why.

1. **AI inside the product.** *ChatIQ* (conversational research assistant, built with Kensho), *Document Intelligence* (analysis across filings, transcripts, investor presentations, news and research), *CIQ Pro AI* for summarisation and comp generation, the *Drift AI* Excel integration, and the *Farsight* partnership generating client-ready pitch decks, CIMs and valuation materials in-platform.
2. **AI-native new products.** *Titan* in Energy — an AI-powered upstream data platform, 113 countries, ~110,000 users, ~4,000 client organisations.
3. **Agent-native architecture — the strategically important one.** S&P is exposing Capital IQ Pro's data and capabilities through **MCP servers**, so clients can reach S&P data through their own AI front-ends and build agentic workflows on

top. Cheung on the Q1 2026 call: *"We are also seeing fast-paced adoption of our AI functionality and are advancing our leadership as we rapidly innovate."*

THE COMMERCIAL TENSION NOBODY AT THE EVENT WILL RAISE BUT EVERYONE SENIOR IS THINKING ABOUT

If clients consume S&P data through their own agents rather than through S&P's screen, **what exactly is being priced?** Seats become meaningless; the unit of value shifts to data rights, query volume or entitlement. That is a pricing and commercial-model problem before it is a technology problem — and it lands squarely on the commercial function. *This is the single strongest panel question available to you (§7.2).*

4.6 Worked examples of the firm's output

- **France downgraded AA– → A+, 20 October 2025.** A snap action citing fiscal and political uncertainty; French bond futures fell on the news. Public debt projected to rise from 112% of GDP (2024) to 121% (2028).
- **Dated Brent, every trading day at 16:30 London.** An assessment that prices hundreds of billions of dollars of annual physical crude trade through OSP formulas and derivative settlements.
- **The S&P 500, continuously since 1957.** Committee-maintained; the most licensed financial object in existence.
- **The Barclays enterprise agreement, July 2025.** Multi-year, enterprise-wide, two-way data relationship (§2.8).
- **S&P Kaiko Digital Asset Indices, 1 September 2026.** 4,000+ rates and indices; S&P provides licensing, distribution and benchmark administration, Kaiko provides the crypto-native data.
- **Private credit and middle-market CLO franchise.** Credit estimates from ~1,200 (2021) to 2,800+ today, tracking a private-credit CLO market of roughly \$155bn — about 16% of the \$977bn US CLO market as of October 2025.

Part 5 — What "commercial functions" actually means here

5.1 The commercial org chart

"Commercial" at S&P Global is an umbrella covering everything that touches revenue and the client, excluding the analytical and product-build functions. In practice it decomposes into six roles.

Function	What they actually do	Measured on
Regional / field sales	Own a territory or a named account list. Generalists across the division's portfolio; first point of contact for the client.	New ACV, retention, pipeline coverage.
Specialist sales	Deep product experts pulled into deals — e.g. Credit & Risk Solutions, Corporate Actions, private markets. They structure complex multi-stakeholder solution sales.	Product-line revenue, win rate on qualified deals.
Customer success / client services	Post-sale. Drive adoption, run usage analytics to spot at-risk accounts and upsell openings, feed client needs back to product, own renewal strategy.	Net revenue retention, churn, usage/adoption metrics.
Channel and partnerships	Third-party distribution — redistributors, platform partners, exchanges, index licensees, technology partners like Kaiko and Farsight.	Partner-sourced revenue, licensing agreements signed.
Enterprise / strategic accounts (Chief Client Office)	The most senior commercial layer. Owns the largest global relationships <i>across divisions</i> — the Barclays-style multi-year enterprise agreements.	Whole-client revenue, cross-divisional penetration.
Commercial marketing	Demand generation, product marketing, event marketing (including this one).	Qualified pipeline generated.

THE PERSON TO KNOW: SALLY MOORE

Sally Moore is EVP, Chief Client Officer and Co-Head of Market Intelligence, Kensho Data & Platforms. She leads S&P Global's *enterprise commercial strategy*, strategic account management at scale, Partnerships and Enterprise Marketing. She is on the Executive Leadership Team and is **S&P Global's Country Head for the United Kingdom.** She joined via the IHS Markit merger, having joined Markit in 2006 and led its European credit and global loan businesses. She is the executive quoted on the Barclays deal.

Why this matters for you: the firm's most senior commercial role is held by someone based in London who also runs the UK. The event you are applying to sits inside her remit. If you want one name to know and one organisational fact to reference, it is this one — the existence of a **Chief Client Office** is itself the evidence that S&P Global has decided cross-divisional commercial capability is a strategic priority rather than an afterthought.

5.2 The metrics that run the commercial function

Use these accurately and you will sound like someone who has worked in a subscription business.

Term	Meaning	Why it matters here
ACV — Annual Contract Value	Annualised value of a contract.	The primary sales currency. With Intelligence was bought partly on "high-teens organic ACV growth".
ARR — Annual Recurring Revenue	Total annualised recurring revenue base.	Moody's Analytics reports ARR of \$3.5bn; the standard comparison metric across the sector.
Net revenue retention	Revenue from last year's cohort this year, including upsell, net of churn and downgrades.	Above 100% means the base grows without a single new client. In a 51%-subscription business this is the master metric.
Churn	Revenue lost from cancellations.	S&P repeatedly emphasises low churn as the reason subscription revenue is a growth engine rather than a treadmill.
Cross-sell / wallet share	How many divisions' products a client buys.	The entire strategic rationale for the Chief Client Office.
Usage / adoption analytics	Whether licensed users actually log in and use the product.	Explicitly how S&P's customer success teams inform renewal strategy and find upsell.

5.3 Four things that make commercial work at S&P Global genuinely unusual

1. **In Ratings, you sell a product you are legally forbidden from influencing.** Analytical separation means the commercial team negotiates fees and relationships while rating committees decide outcomes independently. Your value proposition is access, coverage, timeliness and programme structure — never the answer. No other sales job works like this.
2. **In Indices, you sell to very few, very large counterparties.** The client list is ETF issuers, exchanges, structured-product desks and asset managers. Deals are licences, not seats, and a single one can be worth tens of millions annually. It is closer to business development and partnership structuring than to volume sales.
3. **In Energy, the product's value is the market's collective agreement to use it.** Commercial work includes methodology engagement with the market — participants care intensely about how assessments are constructed, because it moves their contracts. You are selling into a community, not a customer base.
4. **In Market Intelligence, you are the challenger.** You are displacing an incumbent (usually Bloomberg or FactSet) on value, depth and price. This is the most conventional of the four, and the most competitive.

The composite point: "commercial at S&P Global" is four different jobs wearing one name. Saying so demonstrates that you looked past the umbrella term — and it is a natural way to explain why an event covering all four divisions is genuinely useful to you.

5.4 The graduate programme you would actually be applying to

Based on how S&P Global's London commercial graduate schemes have historically been structured:

- **Onboarding:** an intensive induction in London (historically around five weeks), covering products, CRM systems and the divisional landscape.
- **Rotations:** through customer success, sales, channel/partner management and marketing — deliberately designed to give a whole-of-commercial view rather than a single specialism.
- **Content:** e-learning curricula, certification milestones, presentations to senior management, live work on client accounts.
- **Typical responsibilities:** supporting sales teams with research, proposals and account plans; building account overviews; producing data-driven models and templates for clients; marketing material for commercial-culture initiatives and future graduate cohorts; special projects.
- **Duration and progression:** historically an ~18-month programme, after which graduates move into Regional Sales, Specialist Sales, Customer Success, Marketing or Channel/Partner Management.

Treat these as strong indicative expectations from prior cohorts rather than a published 2027 specification — the 2027 structure will be confirmed at the event, and asking about it is a legitimate, well-informed question to put to a recruiter on the day.

5.5 The honest case for and against starting here

The case for	The case against
You learn the plumbing of markets. Ratings, indices and benchmarks are the infrastructure that banking, asset management and trading all sit on top of. Understanding them is portable to almost any finance career.	It is not a front-office markets seat. If your ambition is trading, IB or investing, this is adjacent to it, not it. You will need a deliberate move later.
Genuine client exposure early. Commercial graduates talk to real institutional clients in year one — unusual, and a faster route to commercial judgement than most analyst programmes.	Compensation is corporate, not banking. Materially below front-office finance, particularly in the first three years.
A structurally growing business. 7–9% medium-term organic growth targets, 53 years of dividend increases, high recurring revenue. Growing businesses promote.	The biggest division grows slowest. Most commercial headcount is in Market Intelligence, which grew 6% against Indices' 14%.
The cross-divisional strategy is live. The Chief Client Office is being built now. Being early to a function the firm is actively investing in is a real career advantage.	Rotational breadth can delay depth. Eighteen months across four functions builds range but not yet expertise.
London is the EMEA centre. Third-largest employee base, Chief Client Officer is UK Country Head. This is not a satellite office.	~48% of the workforce is in India. Operational and analytical scale sits there; understand which functions genuinely grow in London.

Part 6 — The event: what it is and how you are being judged

6.1 Why this event exists

Read the advert's own words: "*an exclusive, selection-only event and the direct pathway to our 2027 internship and graduate opportunities. If you are selected to attend, you will receive an invitation to apply for these roles.*"

Decode that. **Attendance is a gate on the 2027 application, not a perk attached to it.** S&P Global has inverted the normal funnel: instead of advertising roles and screening thousands of applications, it screens for the event, curates a room, observes candidates in person for an afternoon, and then invites that pre-qualified pool to apply. The event is the first assessment round.

Why a firm would do this:

- **Commercial roles are hard to screen on paper.** A CV cannot tell you whether someone can hold a room, think on their feet or build rapport with a stranger. A pitch challenge and a networking reception can.
- **Brand problem.** S&P Global loses candidates to banks and consultancies who have never understood what it does. An afternoon with commercial leaders fixes that at low cost.
- **Conversion.** Candidates who have met the team, pitched a product and had a drink with graduates convert to offer acceptance at far higher rates.
- **Diversity of pipeline.** Event-based attraction reaches beyond the usual target-school milk round — which is precisely the specialism of the agency running it (§6.2).

6.2 Who runs it, and what that tells you

The job poster is **Zoe Waxkirsh, Co-Founder and Managing Director of The Ladder Group**. The Ladder Group comprises **The Early Careers Company** (early-careers recruitment and consulting), a second business, and **The Early Careers Foundation**, a social mobility charity. Founded around 2021 by Daniel Ball; the group was subsequently acquired by Unseen Group. Its stated specialism is *equitable recruitment practices, tailored early-careers strategy, and bespoke in-person and virtual attraction events that drive real recruitment outcomes*.

TWO PRACTICAL IMPLICATIONS

One: the advert says "Responses managed off LinkedIn" and applications route to careers.spglobal.com. The first sift may well be run by The Ladder Group against a brief from S&P Global, not by S&P recruiters. That argues for answers that are *clear and self-evidently strong to a non-specialist reader* — sophistication that requires domain knowledge to appreciate can be wasted at sift stage. Put the technical depth in, but make sure the top line of each answer lands without it.

Two: a social-mobility-focused agency means the brief will emphasise potential, motivation and evidence of engagement over pedigree. Do not assume the screen is purely academic.

6.3 The funnel, step by step

#	Stage	What is assessed	Your lever
1	Online application: CV + 100-word answer + panel question. Deadline 23:59 BST, 14 Sep 2026.	Eligibility (2:1 minimum, current student or recent graduate), demonstrated interest, curiosity.	Everything in §7. Apply early — reviewed on a rolling basis.
2	Brief online assessment (shortlist only).	Format unpublished. Comparable early-careers screens are typically situational judgement, numerical/verbal reasoning, or a short recorded video. Expect 20–40 minutes.	Complete it within 24 hours of receipt. Prepare by knowing the four divisions and having two competency stories ready.
3	Invitation to attend (capacity-limited).	Composite of 1 and 2.	—
4	The event, 17 Sep afternoon: leadership presentations; graduate panel Q&A; interactive pitch challenge in small groups with leader feedback and selected groups presenting on stage; overview of 2027 roles; networking reception.	Presence, collaboration, commercial instinct, curiosity, follow-through.	§6.5 and Part 9.
5	Invitation to apply for 2027 internships and graduate roles.	Impressions formed on the day.	Named follow-up within 24 hours.

Context: this is one event in a series. A sibling event, *Ratings Forward*, runs on 24 September 2026 for the Ratings analytical track, with a 21 September deadline and the identical application format (CV, 100-word answer, one panel question, then a brief online assessment). If you are also open to a credit-analysis path, the two are not mutually exclusive — and the identical format means the work you do now is reusable.

6.4 Weighting of the two questions — my read

The advert gives no weighting, so this is inference from the structure. It is a judgement, offered as such.

Component	Est. weight	What it is really testing
CV	~45%	Eligibility gate first (2:1 predicted/achieved, student or recent grad, right to work). Then evidence of commercial aptitude: client-facing work, selling anything, running anything, persuading anyone.
Q1 — why attend (100 words)	~35%	Whether your interest is <i>specific to S&P Global</i> or generic. This is where the sift separates the pile.
Q2 — panel question	~20%	Depth of research and quality of thinking. Low nominal weight, highest variance .

WHY Q2 IS WORTH FAR MORE THAN 20% OF YOUR EFFORT

Q1 has a 100-word cap and an obvious brief. Over a hundred people clicked apply. The realistic distribution of Q1 answers is narrow — most will be competent, few will be distinctive, and the ceiling is low because you cannot say much in 100 words.

Q2 has *no cap and no template*. The modal submission will be something like "What advice would you give someone starting their career?" — a question that reveals nothing and costs nothing. A question that could only have been written by someone who has read the Q2 2026 results or understands the MCP strategy is **instantly separating**. It is also the only part of the application a panellist might actually be shown, since good questions get harvested for the session itself.

Practical allocation: spend 30% of your time on the CV, 30% on Q1, 40% on Q2.

6.5 The pitch challenge — the only competitive element on the day

The advert: *"Participants work in small groups to develop and practise a pitch for a flagship S&P Global product, such as Capital IQ or Ratings. Commercial leaders provide feedback, with selected groups presenting their pitches on stage."*

Two things follow. First, groups are *selected* to present — so there is a visible win condition. Second, you are assessed on **how you behave in the group** at least as much as on the pitch. Commercial leaders watching a group exercise are looking for: does this person structure the problem, do they bring others in, do they concede a better idea gracefully, can they be concise under time pressure.

THE FRAMEWORK TO BRING — FIVE BOXES, FIVE MINUTES

1. **Who is the buyer, precisely?** Not "a bank" — "the head of a mid-market debt origination team with eight analysts". Everything else follows from this.
2. **What is the job they are failing at today?** "My analysts spend six hours building comps that should take one, and the data is inconsistent between decks."
3. **What does the product do about it, in their language?** Two capabilities maximum. Resist listing features.
4. **Why us and not the incumbent?** Name the alternative honestly. For Capital IQ Pro: depth of private-company and transaction data, price per seat, and the bundling nobody else has (ratings + index + Platts + fundamentals in one agreement). For Ratings: coverage, investor recognition, market access — never a promised outcome.
5. **What is the ask?** A trial, a pilot with two users, a meeting with the data team. Close on something concrete.

THE MOVE THAT WINS THE ROOM

Whichever product your group draws, **quantify the value in the client's own currency**. "Eight analysts, six hours a week each, at a fully-loaded cost of roughly £60 an hour, is about £150,000 of analyst time a year on work this automates" is a different conversation from "it's a comprehensive platform". Commercial leaders have watched a thousand feature lists. Almost nobody in a graduate group exercise does the arithmetic out loud.

And if you draw **Ratings**, remember what you cannot pitch: you sell access to capital markets, investor recognition and a credible programme — *never* a rating outcome. Naming that boundary unprompted, in front of commercial leaders from a regulated business, is the strongest single signal available to you on the day.

Part 7 — Your two answers, drafted

7.1 Question 1 — "Why are you interested in attending this event?" (max 100 words)

WHAT THE QUESTION IS REALLY ASKING

Not "why do you want a job". It is asking: **is this person's interest specific, and will they be a good participant?** With 100 words there is no room for a narrative arc. The winning structure is: *a specific and slightly unusual understanding of the firm* → *what you want from the room* → *a note of genuine curiosity*. The failure mode is the generic opener — "S&P Global is a global leader in data and analytics and I am passionate about financial markets" — which is what most of the pile will say.

OPTION A — THE TECHNICAL OPENER (RECOMMENDED)

S&P Global sells the reference points markets organise themselves around — a rating, an index level, a Platts assessment — and I want to understand how those get sold. Commercially that is several jobs: licensing to a handful of ETF issuers, negotiating fees on a product you are legally walled off from influencing, and displacing Bloomberg on a research desk. I want to hear from leaders who do each. I am also curious how the Chief Client Office turns four divisions into one enterprise conversation, as with Barclays. An afternoon with commercial leaders and graduates is the fastest way to test that.

100 words. Why it works: the first sentence demonstrates you understand the business model rather than the marketing. The middle sentence proves you know commercial work here is not one job. "Chief Client Office" and "Barclays" are specific, checkable and current. The close answers the actual question asked.

OPTION B — THE WARMER VERSION, IF YOU WANT THE SIFT READER ON SIDE

Most people my age could not tell you what S&P Global does. I could not either, until I looked properly and found that a number its editors publish at 16:30 each day prices much of the world's physical crude, and that a committee decides what belongs in the S&P 500. That is unusually concrete, and I want to know how you sell something whose value is the market's agreement to use it. I want to hear commercial leaders explain that, meet graduates a few years ahead of me, and pressure-test whether this is the career I think it is.

99 words. Use this if you would rather lead with honesty and curiosity than with technical vocabulary. It handles the "I had no idea what this firm was" starting point head-on and converts it into a virtue. Slightly higher risk, higher warmth.

WHICH TO SEND

Option A. It carries more information per word, and the sift is looking for demonstrated interest, which A evidences and B mostly asserts. Take one sentence of B's voice into A if A reads too clipped when you say it aloud. Whichever you use, **rewrite it in your own idiom before submitting** — a 100-word answer that does not sound like you will be exposed the moment somebody asks you about it in person, and a panel of graduates on 17 September may well do exactly that.

THINGS TO CUT IF YOU WRITE YOUR OWN

- "Passionate about financial markets" — unfalsifiable and universal.
- "Global leader in data and analytics" — their own boilerplate handed back to them.
- Anything about your degree or grades. The CV covers it; the 100 words are too scarce.
- "I would love the opportunity to..." — spends five words saying nothing.
- Naming all four divisions with no distinguishing comment. Listing is not knowledge.

7.2 Question 2 — "One question you would like to ask the panel"

CALIBRATE TO THE PANEL, NOT TO THE CEO

The advert tells you exactly who is on it: "*Case studies from graduates who've launched impactful careers in commercial roles at S&P Global.*" These are people one to five years in, not the executive committee. A question about medium-term margin targets or MCP monetisation would stump them and make the room awkward.

The best question here is one that is **technically informed but answerable — richly — by someone three years into a commercial career**. That constraint eliminates most "impressive" questions and is the single most useful thing in this section.

RECOMMENDED — SEND THIS ONE

PRIMARY

"In Ratings, commercial teams are structurally separated from the analytical process — you can negotiate the relationship but you cannot influence the rating. What does a genuinely good commercial conversation look like when the outcome of the product is off the table, and what did that teach you that you have carried into the rest of your commercial work?"

Why this is the right answer. It proves you understand analytical separation — the one genuinely distinctive feature of commercial work at S&P Global, and something almost no applicant will know exists. It is squarely on the event's theme (commercial functions). It is warm rather than adversarial. Critically, **any commercial graduate can answer it well and enjoy answering it**, which makes it the kind of question a panel host actually selects to use on the day. And if it is used, your name is attached to it.

STRONG ALTERNATIVES, RANKED

2. THE STRATEGY QUESTION (MOST TECHNICALLY IMPRESSIVE)

"S&P Global is exposing Capital IQ Pro through MCP servers so clients can reach the data through their own AI agents. If clients increasingly consume data through their agents rather than through your platform, what is the commercial unit you are actually selling — seats, queries, or data rights — and how is that changing the conversations you have with clients?"

The highest-ceiling question in this list and a real unresolved strategic issue. Risk: a two-year graduate may not have a good answer. **Better used in person with a commercial leader on the day than as your written submission.**

3. THE GROWTH-ASYMMETRY QUESTION

"Last quarter Indices grew 20% while Energy grew 3%, largely for reasons outside anyone's control — sanctions and volatility. Where does a commercial team actually add the most value: in a division riding structural growth, or in one facing headwinds it cannot influence?"

Demonstrates you have read the Q2 2026 numbers. Excellent, answerable, and it invites a genuinely interesting answer. Slight risk of reading as a challenge — soften the delivery if you use it live.

4. THE ENTERPRISE-SELLING QUESTION

"The Barclays agreement was enterprise-wide and two-way — Barclays got access across the portfolio and contributed its own data back into S&P's pricing services. Is that becoming the template for the largest relationships, and how does a commercial team learn to sell across four divisions rather than one?"

Directly relevant to the Chief Client Office strategy and easy for a graduate to engage with from their own experience of cross-divisional working.

5. THE PRIVATE-MARKETS QUESTION

"Burgiss sits inside MSCI, Preqin inside BlackRock and PitchBook inside Morningstar, and S&P positions iLEVEL and With Intelligence as a complementary asset-level category rather than a direct competitor. How do you sell 'a new category' to a client who already believes they have bought private markets data?"

A real commercial problem, precisely stated. Slightly narrow for a general panel, but outstanding in a one-to-one with a specialist salesperson.

QUESTIONS TO AVOID

Don't ask	Why not
"What advice would you give someone starting their career?"	The modal submission. Reveals nothing about you and produces a generic answer.
"What does a typical day look like?"	Answered on the careers site. Signals you did not look.
"What is the culture like?"	Nobody has ever answered this informatively at a recruiting event.
"How do I stand out in the application?"	Asks them to do your work, in writing, on your application.
Anything about salary, hours or promotion timelines.	Correct question, wrong forum. Ask a graduate privately at the reception.
A question whose premise is wrong (e.g. treating Mobility as a current division).	Worse than a dull question. Verify every fact you assert.

7.3 CV adjustments for this specific application

The CV carries the largest single weight and it is the part you are most likely to submit unchanged. Four targeted edits:

1. **Make the 2:1 impossible to miss.** The eligibility bar is an explicit stated requirement: strong academics and a minimum 2:1 predicted or achieved. Put degree, institution, and predicted or achieved classification in the first three lines. If a sifter has to hunt for it, you risk being screened out on an administrative basis rather than a judgement one.
2. **Reframe one bullet in commercial language.** Anything involving persuading, selling, negotiating, recruiting, fundraising, pitching, or retaining people or clients should be described in those verbs, with a number attached. Society sponsorship, a part-time retail or hospitality job, a society you grew, a competition you pitched in — all of these are commercial evidence if described as such. "Raised £X from Y sponsors" beats "held a committee position".
3. **Add one line of demonstrated market interest.** A stock pitch, an investment society, a modelling competition, a relevant reading habit, a personal project. The eligibility criterion is literally *"able to demonstrate an interest in, and curiosity to learn more about, a commercial career at S&P Global"* — give the sifter something concrete to point at.
4. **One page, plain formatting, no columns, no tables, no graphics.** Assume it is parsed by an applicant tracking system before a human sees it. Multi-column layouts and text boxes routinely scramble on extraction, and this application is being handled through a third-party workflow.

If you want, I can run a full ATS parse-audit and tailoring pass on your actual CV against this advert — that is a separate piece of work and worth doing before you submit.

Part 8 — Talking-point bank: 30 things most applicants won't know

Each with the "so what". Learn the ones you can deliver naturally; a fact you fumble is worse than one you never mention.

#	Fact	So what
1	Commodity Insights was renamed S&P Global Energy on 14 Nov 2025 at Investor Day.	You read primary sources, not the job ad.
2	Mobility was spun off on 1 July 2026 as Mobility Global Inc (MBGL), 1-for-1 distribution.	The four divisions in the advert are the entire company now.
3	Mobility was removed because automotive clients shared no sales force or distribution with the rest of the firm.	A <i>commercial</i> rationale for a corporate action — exactly the lens they want.
4	FY2025: \$15.336bn revenue, +8%; adjusted EPS \$17.83 , +14%.	Baseline numeracy.
5	Adjusted margins: Indices 71% , Ratings 65% , Energy 48% , Market Intelligence 34% .	The spread is the story, not the average.
6	MI's margin is lower because its data must be continuously collected and it faces four real competitors; index rules do not need re-collecting.	You can explain <i>why</i> , not just recite.
7	Subscription is 51% of revenue; ~68% recurs in some form.	Retention beats new logos here — the correct commercial priority.
8	Q2 2026: Indices +20% (13th consecutive record quarter), Ratings +17% , MI +6%, Energy +3%.	Current, checkable, and shows you follow the firm.
9	Q2 2026 Ratings transaction revenue +25% to \$746m ; non-transaction +8% to \$593m.	You understand the two halves of the ratings model.
10	S&P 500 ETF licensing is around 3bp of AUM plus a fixed fee ; >95% of index licence fees are AUM-based.	The single best illustration of operating leverage in the firm.
11	CME pays per-contract royalties on E-mini S&P 500 futures; volumes rise in volatility.	A natural hedge against falling AUM fees in a selloff.
12	S&P 500 membership is decided by a committee , not a pure rulebook — unlike FTSE Russell.	A real, defensible point of differentiation and controversy.
13	Platts assesses Dated Brent at 16:30:00 London , reflecting the most competitive qualifying North Sea grade for cargoes loading 10–21 days forward .	Nobody else in the room will have this.
14	Platts publishes bids, offers and trades during the MOC window; participants must be willing to transact on what they post.	Explains why the assessment is credible.
15	Argus North Sea Dated uses a basket of five grades (Brent, Forties, Oseberg, Ekofisk, Troll) plus WTI Midland, triangulated with CFDs.	You know the competitor's methodology, not just its name.
16	The DoJ forced divestiture of OPIS, Coal Metals & Mining and PetroChem Wire to News Corp as a condition of the IHS Markit merger.	Regulators judged price benchmarks the dangerous part — a sharp observation.
17	CUSIP Global Services was sold to FactSet for \$1.925bn in the same clearance.	S&P sold a monopoly asset to a competitor to get the deal done.
18	The IHS Markit merger closed 28 Feb 2022 at \$44bn enterprise value, all-stock.	Largest deal ever in capital-markets information.
19	With Intelligence acquired from Motive Partners for \$1.8bn , completed 25 Nov 2025; ~\$130m revenue, high-teens organic ACV growth.	You use ACV correctly and know the price.
20	iLEVEL serves ~700 clients and touches roughly 16,000 funds of GP-to-LP reporting.	The specific asset behind the private-markets claim.

21	Burgiss → MSCI, Preqin → BlackRock, PitchBook → Morningstar, With Intelligence → S&P Global.	You can map a whole consolidating market in one line.
22	EDM and thinkFolio sold to Symphony Technology Group, 12 Jan 2026, \$172m pre-tax gain ; geoscience software going to SLB .	Evidence for the "sell the software, keep the data" thesis.
23	Titan : AI-native upstream platform, 113 countries , ~110,000 users, ~4,000 client organisations.	Shows you follow Energy, the least-discussed division.
24	S&P exposes Capital IQ Pro via MCP servers so client agents can consume its data.	The most forward-looking thing the firm is doing.
25	Farsight partnership + minority investment (Jul 2026): generates pitch decks, CIMs and valuation materials inside Capital IQ Pro.	Concrete AI-in-product example, two months old.
26	S&P Kaiko Digital Asset Indices announced 1 Sep 2026 — 4,000+ rates and indices; S&P provides licensing, distribution and benchmark administration.	Sixteen days old at the event. S&P monetised its <i>administration</i> , not its data.
27	Sally Moore , Chief Client Officer, is also UK Country Head and quoted on the Barclays deal.	The firm's top commercial role sits in London.
28	Barclays got enterprise-wide access; Barclays contributed its own data back into S&P's pricing services.	The client became a supplier — a commercial model, not a sale.
29	Credit estimates grew from ~1,200 (2021) to 2,800+ ; private-credit CLOs ~\$155bn, ~16% of the \$977bn US CLO market (Oct 2025).	The specific mechanism by which private credit reaches Ratings' P&L.
30	53 consecutive years of dividend increases; FY2025 returned \$6.2bn — 113% of adjusted free cash flow .	Growth must come from the existing base, not from spending. That is a commercial mandate.

HOW TO USE THESE WITHOUT SOUNDING REHEARSED

Pick **four**, not thirty. One about the business model (#10 or #13), one about strategy (#22 or #24), one current (#26), one commercial (#28). Deploy each only where it answers a question someone actually asked. Reciting facts unprompted reads as anxiety; producing the right one at the right moment reads as fluency. And if you are unsure of a number, give the shape rather than the digits — "margins in the high sixties" is safer and just as convincing as a figure you might get wrong.

Part 9 — Questions they will ask you, and how to answer

"SO, WHAT DO YOU KNOW ABOUT S&P GLOBAL?"

Answer: "It sells the reference points markets price risk against — a credit rating, an index level, a Platts assessment, a company record. Four divisions since Mobility spun out in July. What surprised me is how different the four businesses are commercially: Indices licenses to a handful of very large counterparties, Ratings has commercial teams legally separated from the analysts, and Market Intelligence is a challenger fighting Bloomberg on a research desk. I wanted to hear how that works in practice, which is partly why I applied."

Why it works: it answers in one breath, demonstrates structure, and hands them three threads to pull on. Never list the four divisions and stop.

"WHY COMMERCIAL, AND NOT ANALYTICAL OR CREDIT?"

Answer: "Because the interesting problem here is not producing the intelligence, it is getting a client to change how they work. S&P has assets nobody else can bundle — ratings, indices, Platts and fundamentals in one agreement. But breadth only creates value if the divisions actually sell together, which is presumably why the Chief Client Office exists. That is the problem I want to work on. And I would rather be in the conversation with the client than one step behind it."

"WHY S&P GLOBAL RATHER THAN A BANK OR A CONSULTANCY?"

Answer: "Two reasons. First, I would rather learn the infrastructure than one seat on top of it — ratings, indices and benchmarks sit underneath every bank and every asset manager, so understanding them travels. Second, this is a growing business with a commercial function it is actively building out rather than one that has been fixed for thirty years. That is a better place to be early."

Do not disparage banking. Some of the people asking will have come from it.

"WHICH DIVISION INTERESTS YOU MOST?"

Answer (adapt to who you are talking to, but commit): "Indices, for the economics — asset-linked fees on a product with essentially zero marginal cost, which is why it grew 20% last quarter. But commercially I think Market Intelligence is the harder and more interesting job, because you are the challenger and you have to win on value rather than incumbency. I would want to understand both before choosing."

Committing to a view and then qualifying it reads as judgement. Refusing to choose reads as evasion.

"WHAT DO YOU THINK THE BIGGEST CHALLENGE FACING THE FIRM IS?"

Answer: "Honestly, what AI does to the value of a research desktop. If clients' agents can assemble analysis from anywhere, a per-seat platform fee is harder to defend. S&P's answer seems to be to bet that licensed, rights-cleared, auditable data becomes more valuable when everything else is generated — which is why they are exposing Capital IQ Pro through MCP servers rather than defending the screen. I think that is the right bet, but it changes what a commercial team is actually selling."

This is the answer that will get you remembered. It names a real risk, credits the firm's response, and lands on the commercial implication.

"SELL ME THIS PEN / PITCH ME CAPITAL IQ PRO IN A MINUTE."

Structure: "Who am I talking to?" — always ask first; the question tests whether you qualify before you pitch. Then: buyer → the job they are failing at → two capabilities → the honest alternative → a concrete ask. Quantify in their currency (§6.5).

"TELL ME ABOUT A TIME YOU PERSUADED SOMEONE."

Structure: situation, the specific resistance, what you did differently *because of* that resistance, the measurable outcome, what you would do differently. Sixty to ninety seconds. The middle section is the whole answer — most people describe what they wanted rather than what the other person needed.

THREE QUESTIONS TO ASK *THEM* AT THE RECEPTION

- **To a graduate:** "What is the thing about the job that nobody tells you in the recruitment process?"
- **To a commercial leader:** "When you look at a graduate after twelve months, what separates the ones who are going to be good at this?"
- **To a recruiter:** "What does the 2027 process look like from here, and is there anything I should be doing between now and then?" — this is the one that converts an event into an application.

Part 10 — Glossary: zero to fluent

Term	Definition
ACV / ARR	Annual Contract Value / Annual Recurring Revenue. The two standard measures of a subscription book.
Analytical separation	The regulatory requirement that commercial staff at a rating agency are structurally walled off from rating decisions.
Asset-linked fees	Index licence revenue calculated as basis points on AUM tracking the index.
Basis point (bp)	One hundredth of a percent. 3bp on \$400bn is \$120m.
BDC	Business Development Company — a listed vehicle lending to middle-market firms; a private-credit structure S&P rates.
CFD	Contract for Difference — in crude, a swap on the spread between dated and forward Brent; used in assessment triangulation.
CLO	Collateralised Loan Obligation — a securitisation of corporate loans, tranching and rated. Middle-market CLOs hold private-credit loans.
Credit estimate	A lighter-touch, unpublished credit assessment used mainly in middle-market CLO analysis. S&P has 2,800+.
CreditWatch	S&P's formal flag that a rating is under review for possible change.
Dated Brent	Platts' assessment of physical light North Sea crude for cargoes loading 10–21 days forward. A core global oil benchmark.
ESMA	European Securities and Markets Authority — direct supervisor of credit rating agencies in the EU under Regulation 1060/2009.
ETD royalties	Per-contract fees paid by exchanges on futures and options referencing an index.
Frequent issuer programme	A negotiated annual arrangement covering all of a repeat issuer's ratings, rather than deal-by-deal fees.
Investment grade	BBB– and above on the S&P scale. Below is high yield / speculative grade. The boundary drives mandate eligibility.
Issuer-pays	The model in which the entity being rated pays for the rating. Standard since the 1970s; the source of the structural conflict.
MCP	Model Context Protocol — a standard for exposing data and tools to AI agents. S&P is publishing Capital IQ Pro through it.
MOC	Market on Close — Platts' structured price-discovery window ending at 16:30:00 London.
Net revenue retention	This year's revenue from last year's clients, including upsell, net of churn. Above 100% means the base grows by itself.
NRSRO	Nationally Recognized Statistical Rating Organization — SEC designation whose ratings can be referenced in US regulation.
OSP	Official Selling Price — the price a national oil company sets, typically as a differential to a published assessment.
PRA	Price Reporting Agency — Platts, Argus, OPIS. Firms that assess and publish commodity prices.
Surveillance	Ongoing monitoring of an outstanding rating. Generates recurring non-transaction revenue.

Transaction vs non-transaction

In Ratings: one-off new-issue fees vs recurring surveillance and programme fees.

Appendix — Sources

All figures are drawn from the sources below and are current to the dates stated. Financial figures come from S&P Global's own SEC filings and earnings releases wherever possible. Market-share estimates, licensing-fee structures and competitor private-company figures are third-party estimates and are flagged as approximate in the text.

PRIMARY — S&P GLOBAL FILINGS AND RELEASES

- Form 10-K, FY2025 (filed 2026) — segment descriptions, competition, regulation, risk factors.
- Form 8-K, Q4 & FY2025 earnings release — revenue by segment and type, margins, adjusted EPS, capital return, 2026 guidance.
- Form 8-K, Q1 2026 earnings release — segment revenue and growth, margins, CEO commentary.
- Form 10-Q, quarter ended 30 June 2026 — H1 2026 revenue, Mobility separation effective 1 July 2026, divestitures held for sale.
- Q2 2026 earnings coverage and call transcript — divisional growth rates, transaction/non-transaction split, guidance revisions.
- Investor Day 2025 (13 Nov 2025) — medium-term targets, three strategic objectives, buyback authorisation.
- Press releases: *S&P Global Introduces S&P Global Energy* (14 Nov 2025); *Completes \$1.8 Billion Acquisition of With Intelligence* (25 Nov 2025); *S&P Global and Barclays Partner on a Multi-Year Strategic Agreement* (23 Jul 2025); *New Strategic Direction for Upstream Energy Business* (24 Apr 2026); *S&P DJI and Pantera Capital Launch New Index for Digital Assets* (21 Jul 2026); *S&P DJI and Kaiko Introduce S&P Kaiko Digital Asset Indices* (1 Sep 2026); *Market Intelligence Partners with Farsight* (Jul 2026); *S&P Global Announces Executive Leadership Team*.
- S&P Global Energy methodology pages — Platts crude oil methodology; Dated Brent price explained.
- S&P Global Ratings — private credit and middle-market CLO research; regulatory disclosures; France rating action (20 Oct 2025).
- S&P Global Investor Fact Book — revenue by division, acquisitions and divestitures, AI strategy.

PRIMARY — COMPETITORS AND REGULATORS

- Moody's Corporation FY2025 results and 2025 Annual Report.
- MSCI Inc. Q4 and FY2025 results.
- FactSet Research Systems FY2025 (year ended 31 Aug 2025) results and Form 10-K.
- LSEG FY2025 preliminary results (26 Feb 2026).
- Argus Media — Argus Crude methodology; Argus North Sea Dated methodology.
- SEC, *2024 Staff Report on Nationally Recognized Statistical Rating Organizations* (Jan 2025).
- ESMA — CRA authorisation materials and public notices concerning S&P Global Ratings Europe Limited.
- US Department of Justice — press release on required divestitures for the S&P Global / IHS Markit merger; Davis Polk deal summary.

SECONDARY AND ANALYTICAL

- An, Benetton and Sun, *Index Providers: Whales Behind the Scenes of ETFs* (Journal of Financial Economics; NYU/Harvard Corporate Governance versions) — index licensing fee structures.
- ETFdb, *Indexing Industry Revenues Hit Record \$7.2bn* (May 2026); ETF Stream on index-provider concentration.
- Oxford Institute for Energy Studies, *Brent Prices: Impact of PRA Methodology on Price Formation*.
- A-Team Insight — *S&P Global Bets on Agent-Native Architecture; S&P Global's Private Markets Data Play*.
- Financial Stability Board, *Report on Vulnerabilities in Private Credit* (6 May 2026).
- Wall Street Prep and comparable industry sources on Bloomberg / Capital IQ / FactSet / LSEG positioning and seat share.
- The Ladder Group and The Early Careers Company corporate materials.
- Prosple UK and Bright Network listings for prior S&P Global London commercial graduate programmes (used for \$5.4, flagged as indicative).
- LinkedIn job posting 4459330616, *Client Forward: Early Careers in Commercial Functions at S&P Global*; and the parallel *Ratings Forward* posting.

A note on confidence. Figures from S&P Global's SEC filings and earnings releases are exact. Market shares in ratings (~40/40/15–20) and in financial-data seats (~6% Capital IQ) are third-party estimates that vary by methodology — quote them as approximations. The S&P 500 licensing structure (~3bp plus a fixed fee) is drawn from academic and industry analysis of published fund arrangements, not from S&P disclosure; describe it

as "reported to be around three basis points" rather than as fact. Graduate programme details in §5.4 reflect prior cohorts and should be confirmed at the event. The weighting analysis in §6.4 is my inference from the application structure, not published guidance.